Etherian Mall

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/21347020.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora/Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Angella/Micah (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Catra & Double Trouble, Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra), Kyle/Rogelio (She-Ra), Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra), Lonnie/Scorpia (One-sided), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Kyle & Lonnie & Rogelio (She-ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Light Hope, Shadow Weaver, Huntara (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Mall AU, Slice of Life, they're all adults, Except Frosta she's still like 12, Catra Applesauce Meowmeow, Shadow Weaver is still a bitch, Unrequited Crush, retail hell, Fuck Horde Prime

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Etherian Mall

by Adrian_B

Summary

A series of interconnected one-shots following the She-Ra cast in the hell that is retail work. Customer Service is a stressful, thankless job. At least hey can vent about it to each other.

Chapter 1

Chapter Summary

In which Scorpia exists and for that Catra is grateful.

"Thank you, we'll call your name out when your order is up, right over there." Pointing down towards the other end of the counter were a few other coffees and frappes sat, Catra pushed the register closed as she finished with another transaction. The mall Coffee Horde that she worked out, while not nearly as crowded as the branches around office buildings or the general downtown area, the store still got busy during lunch. She was finally getting a break in the line for the first time in twenty minutes and was debating whether she had time to clock out for her own lunch break.

Her ears twitched as did her nose at the overpowering smell of coffee, she remembered when she first started working here at the wee age of sixteen, side by side with Adora, struggling to keep up with the chaos. The smells had been too much and would always make her feel sick, but she had overcome it and persevered, despite everyone telling her she'd be better off quitting, despite her manager at the time, Shadow Weaver, constantly verbally abusing her, after Adora up and bailed for a new job, after Scorpia and Entrapta ditched for new jobs. Despite everything, Catra was still here at the ripe age of twenty-two. Maybe it was pure stubbornness and spite that kept her tethered to this coffee shop despite how obviously terrible it was for her.

"Wildcat!" Even before looking up, she knew who it was based off the genuine excitement and affection attached to the name. Looking out towards the doors, she saw the familiar giant of a woman, scorpion claws and tails, side-shaved white hair and warm smile of one Scopria. She was decked out in the classic green and beige uniform of the greenhouse, with a flowery apron over her front as her tail curled and uncurled behind her.

“Hey, Scorpia,” Catra replied, putting on a warm, if not tired, smile on her face. Far more genuine than the convincing, yet still hollow retail smile she wore in front of customers. “Are you on your lunch break?”

“Yep, I have… twenty more minutes,” Scorpia announced after stealing a quick glance at her phone to double check. “Naturally I had to come here as fast as I could to see my best friend and get some food.”

“Ten minutes to get here? The greenhouse isn’t that far away.”

Giving a laugh, Scorpia rubbed the back of her head. “I would have been faster, but I ran into Lonnie on my way out and we started talking.”

“Right,” Catra said, not missing the faint blush Scorpia got at the mention of the girls name, and grinned, “Well, you’re here so what’s it matter?”

Nodding her head, Scorpia looked up at the menu, not that she needed to, she probably still had it memorized from her time as an employee. “I’ll have, a muffin. Oh, do you have any more chocolate chip ones? If not, I’ll have a blueberry muffin.”

Nodding, Catra moved to the bakery display case, scanning the array of baked goods until she found a chocolate chip muffin, using the tongs to withdraw it from the others and stuffing it in the brown paper bag. She paused, glanced around to see if anyone was watching before holding it out towards Scorpia from over the top of the case. “Don’t tell anyone,” she said with a finger to her lips and giving her friend a wink.

Scorpia gave a small gasp as she took it in her pinchers, “Catra, are you sure?” she said, holding it close to herself as if to hide to treat from sight, giving a conspiratorial glance around the inside of the coffee shop—one that only made it that much more obvious they were doing something they shouldn’t.

“It’s fine, really,” Rolling her eyes a little, she walked back towards the register, tapping away at the screen and checking to see if there were any incoming customers or if Kyle and Rogelio were having any trouble with their orders. “Give me a minute to clock out for my own break and I’ll meet you outside, alright? We can go somewhere else until your breaks over.”

“You don’t want to stay here?”

“Scorpia, if I have to spend more time than I need to in here, I’ll lose my mind.”

Grinning and nodding in understanding, Scorpia began backing away, “Got it, I’ll wait outside, we can head over to Bright Moon then,” she said and bumped into another customer, apologizing profusely before exiting the store.

Catra rolled her eyes as she watched her friend leave, already punching the muffin into the register and swiping her card through the machine. She was grateful Scorpia still visited even after she quit, having a friend like her made the job a bit more tolerable.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

In which Glimmer is exhausted and gay.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"*Uuuuugh!*"

If Glimmer slouched any farther, she'd have to fuse herself with the empty table she draped herself over, burying her face in her arms. She was tired and stressed, which had caused today to be one of those days where her fuse was at its shortest. Everything was terrible, plain and simple. From the moment she arrived at work today, everything had been nothing short of an absolute disaster.

They'd run out of banana nut muffins, and the newbie, some blonde, hardcore 'save the environment' guy who spoke like a surfer (apparently he knew her friend Perfuma?) make them in the kitchen, and boy did he make a mess of everything. There had been batter on the *ceiling*! Then she had to deal with customers who couldn't seem to do basic math and kept demanding why their total came up to nineteen dollars and refused to listen no matter how many times she explained it (thank God for Bow stepping in before she ended up throwing a cupcake at the woman's face). To top it off, the register didn't have any more ones in it and she didn't find out until there was a line of customers because all her customers before that moment had been using credit and debit cards, and no one else was available to watch the line while she ran back to the office to get some from the safe, which resulted in more cranky customers, which only made her mood worsen with each order.

She hated her job. Plain and simple. Who in their right mind would ever want to work customer service and enjoy it?

Customers were terrible!

It only got worse, though, because of course it had to get worse. Of course Catra had to stop by with Scorpia during the lull Bright Moon's Bakery had finally gotten, when Glimmer didn't have either Adora or Bow to act as a buffer between her and the magicat, because they had to run over to *another* store to pick up more flour since the new guy somehow lost their last jumbo bag. How do you loose a bag of flour? How!?

But, ugh, just dealing with Catra is the worse. Glimmer absolutely hated that cocky grin she always got and the way she teased and flirted like it wasn't a big deal. She hated how self-centered and confident the woman was, like she was some kind of queen. And worst of all, as soon as she and Scorpia showed up, the first thing Catra asked? *"Hey, Sparkles, Adora hiding out in the kitchen or something?"*

It really shouldn't bother her nearly as much as it does. Catra and Adora have *history*, basically grew up together. Of course Catra would only come over to the mall's bakery to see Adora, she had no other reason to want to stop by. But it wasn't like Glimmer could actually be mad at Adora for it, either. Her best friend was oblivious to Catra's blatant flirting, or maybe she was just so used to it she didn't notice anymore, and she clearly didn't seem to realize that Catra only stopped by of her own volition to see her. And why wouldn't Catra do that? Adora was amazing. Adora was tall, strong and beautiful, she had a heart of gold and was a completely clueless dork.

Catra and Adora were probably going to get together at some point. They were both very attractive people, their personalities clashed, but complemented each other wonderfully, they had history and knew each other better than anyone else, and by the way they acted they clearly had a crush on each other but were too stubborn or clueless to make the first move—knowing them it was probably both. And the thought just bothered Glimmer so much more than it should.

It was completely reasonable to have a crush on Adora—it was impossible for anyone who liked women *not* to have a crush on her at some point. But Catra? For the love of God, Glimmer, you were supposed to have *standards* and *good taste*! Not that it even matters because you won't end up with either of the two girls you're crushing on. Go figure.

"Glimmer!" she tried not to show how excited she was to look up as Adora approached, dusted in flour and dough sticking to her uniform shirt. Bow was in tow, smiling just as much and not nearly as batter-covered as Adora. They slid into the seats across from her, smiles faltering to concern. "You okay? You look like you're trying to be one with the table."

"Because I am, my life goal has always been to become a table," Glimmer responded dryly and then shook her head. "I'm tired, stressed and if one more person starts giving me an unsolicited lecture on why our non-vegan products shouldn't be allowed, I'm going to punch someone."

Bow grimaced, "If you do that, you're going to get fired," he pointed out.

To which Glimmer could only give an empty laugh. "Yeah, like my mom's going to fire me," she rolled her eyes and sunk back against the pastel-pink table. "She fires me and Shadow Weaver will take my position as assistant manager. You know she doesn't want that."

"I'm sure it hasn't been that bad," Adora had no right to be so genuine and have such an amazing smile as she tried to cheer Glimmer up, no right at all. "Look, we just have two more hours of our shift, then we can go do something else. We can watch some movies and relax."

Glimmer finally found herself smiling a little. "That sounds fun, actually."

“Oooh, we can invite Catra, Scorpia and Entrapta to join us! The Best Friend Squad and the Super Pal Trio joint movie night!” Bow declared excitedly.

That… sounded less fun. But Glimmer forced herself to keep smiling. “I mean, if they’re free, why not?” she relented. She didn’t mind Scorpia, Entrapta might be a bit much at times, and Catra was… Catra. But, anything would be better than being stuck here any longer.

As much as she wanted to stay sitting and chatting with her friends, especially since they just got back, she knew she couldn't, or rather, shouldn't. Her break was going to be over soon, anyway. So Glimmer pushed herself from her seat and forced herself to put on her “Hello, Valued Customer!” smile as she made her way back to the counter before Shadow Weaver could slither out from nowhere and ask her in that annoying ‘I’m being civil and at the same time demeaning you’ voice if Glimmer was done with work because why else would she be sitting with her friends and chatting rather than working? Seriously, how had Adora put up with the woman for so long? How had her *dad* put up with her when he was a kid?

Customers were already pouring back into the bakery, as if somehow knowing Glimmer was now off break and available to torment. She forced her smile to stay even as the smell of burned cookies filled the air.

Chapter End Notes

> It's pretty much 3 am, forgive me if there are spelling errors on this chap.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

In which Hordak is a disaster at romance.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I don't think the landlady was particularly thrilled when Emily began following her with the knife, but even she has to see what a monumental advancement it was with her programing! But then Emily ran into a couch and got stuck because the knife went into the furniture," Entrapta recounted, her enthusiasm calming for a brief moment as she reached the point where Emily got stuck. "I managed to wrench her free and then, for safety precautions, removed the knife before allowing her to roam free. I'll need to do some adjustments to her spacial awareness, but she's coming along well!" with that, the enthusiasm was back as she threw her arms out with the finale of her tale.

Hordak quietly reached over and pulled her coffee away from her just a bit so that she didn't knock it over by accident (again) as she moved her arms about while talking. As much as he loved seeing her like this, they were surrounded by expensive technology and he would rather avoid having hot coffee knocked all over the display phones and laptops again. Sure, Entrapta had fixed everything, but why risk it a second time when they could avoid it?

Still, he hid his smile as he brought his own coffee to his mouth to take a sip. So far it had been a rather slow day for the Etherian branch of the Fright Zone, slow enough that he supposed there was time to stop and chat rather than work. Well, for him and Entrapta, he made sure the other employees currently clocked in were busy doing inventory or shelving supplies.

"It is fascinating how you managed to change what had been a simple Roomba into what it—she is now," he quickly corrected

himself when he referred to Emily, knowing how important the machine was to Entrapta, he would loathe upsetting Entrapta again by calling her creation an 'it', and what a great creation she was. Entrapta was slowly giving the machine a form of artificial intelligence.

He knew that Entrapta was smart, perhaps the most intelligent person he knew, and yet it never failed to amaze him whenever she went on about a project of hers. He was honored to have her as a friend and a partner, she was perhaps the first person to truly understand him.

And, well, perhaps he'd like to be more than just 'lab partners' as she often referred to them as. It was why today was to be such an important day for him. He'd spent the past few weeks compiling information on ways to go about this from various sources, and had been taking every precaution he could find to make sure that this went as smoothly as possible.

He'd been careful to make sure that Entrapta had time to do what she wanted when she arrived by keeping her off the register, be it tinkering with the different gadgets they sold or doing observations on the different customers that came in. He'd bought her coffee to keep her going (From his own Coffee Horde, of course), knowing she had probably gone without sleep the night before to work on Emily, and he had even brought her breakfast for when she'd arrived that morning; half a dozen tiny blueberry muffins from that obscenely colorful bakery that she loved so much. She had been so happy for the food that his heart almost couldn't take it, and when it was clear she was eager to talk about something great—the story of Emily and the landlady—he'd made sure they had time and privacy in the side of the store to chat.

Now was just the hardest part. He'd done everything right so far, now he just had to find the words to actually ask her. "Entrapta," he began, lowering his coffee back down, trying to stay calm, to not show weakness. "I've been meaning to ask you something for a while now."

There was that scientific curiosity in her eyes as she leaned forward, hair lifting her up so she was able to look him in the eyes at a level height. “Oh? What is it?” she asked, smiling at him in a way that made it even harder to find his voice and words. “Is this about that project you’ve been working on for Prime? I’m still waiting on some parts to arrive in the mail, but I can probably make substitutes out of things from around the apartment if you’re in a rush.”

The—oh, right, that. He’d nearly forgotten about their project together with all the focus he’d been putting in just asking her out. “No, no, it’s not that,” he corrected. From the corner of his eye, he saw Octavio peer at them curiously, a knowing smile fell on her face, but quickly dropped as he turned to give a glare and a look that needed no words to convey the message; get back to work or else. She lost a shade or two of color and hurried back to the stack of boxed phones to put on the shelves.

Now, back to the issue at hand. “I wanted to discuss you and me,” he paused, finding his nerves beginning to fail him. When did he become just so *weak*? “You and I, we’ve ah, we’ve been working together for quite some time by now.”

“Yes! Approximately thirty-one months if my calculations are correct,” Entrapta interjected, then faltered, remembering that most people, Hordak in particular, don’t enjoy being interrupted. “Oh, right, sorry. Go on.” Well, he was fine with her cutting in like that.

He coughed to clear his throat and buy him a few seconds. “Ah, yes, for thirty-one months,” so much time, it had flown by so quickly. “I was thinking we might be able to,” come on, Hordak, you’ve been preparing for this, you’re a cutthroat businessman, smarter than most, a fearless leader. You can do this. You’re not afraid, you’re not going to crumble now. “to move our relationship to the next step?”

He could have sworn he heard one of his employees fighting back laughter after he said that, but couldn’t find the source, lucky for

them or he'd have written them up for the sheer audacity. But instead, he focused on Entrapta, her expression as he waited for some answer. A yes, preferably, he hadn't actually prepared for her to say 'no'.

Entrapta just looked at him for a few moments and then a wide smile broke across her face—yes! A good sign! "I've heard about this before! I can't say I'm particularly well versed in the concept, but I've done some research in the past so I'm familiar with it," right she seems excited, all good signs, not a concrete yes, but the way she was acting, it didn't seem like she was going to say no. Hordak's heart was starting to race with anticipation, more so than it already was. "But, yes, I think it's only logical that we move forward after being partners for so long."

The smile that found its way on his face couldn't be stopped, and it wasn't as if he hadn't tried. He smiled, felt pride rush through him at having been able to ask, and even more for her to have said yes. "You're sure?" he asked, just to be certain he wasn't imagining it, but she didn't deny or reject. "Then this Friday, would be you free to join me for dinner? There's this wonderful restaurant that I've been wanting to take you to for some time now, they even serve miniature-sized food." It was one of the businesses owned by Prime, and though tiny food wasn't technically on the menu, he'd be able to get the chefs to cook it that way for her.

"Friday? I should be available, I might have to push some things around to make sure," she mumbled the last bit to herself as she went over a mental list of tasks and appointments she may have for that day. "I'll have to do quite a bit of research and data collecting, though, so I might not be able to bring too much to the table when we meet. But I should be able to find business books, or lessons online, I can spend my free time studying up."

"No worries, if it doesn't work, we can schedule it for a different day," Hordak was quick to assure her and even quicker to stop when he processed what else she said. "Business? I, if you don't mind my asking, what would that have to do with this?"

She was still smiling, even as she lowered herself back onto the floor, some of her hair reaching out to grab her laptop and start typing away, getting a jumpstart on this research. "Since our partnership is moving up, I assume you'll want me to have a better understanding of business theories and concepts," she answered as if it was the most sensible thing in the world. "I can tell you everything about science, but there's only so much I can do as a new business partner with my current understanding of said business."

Business partner, but that wasn't…

Oh.

Oh no…

Hordak wanted to throw something or slap himself, maybe both. She didn't actually say yes, he had his hopes up for nothing. He'd asked her out and Entrapta had interpreted it as him asking her if she'd want to be more his partner in business rather than just his, his *partner*. Oh, was he really so bad at this?

There was more muffled laughter and this time he was able to catch the fleeting figure of Imp darting away after watching this disaster unfold.

But, Entrapta was looking at him now, and Hordak couldn't possible pull the rug out from under her and tell he that no, he didn't want her to help him run this place, not when she looked so excited to do it. This would be a new way to study social interactions, and to even study the science of business, he couldn't take that away from her.

"You're right," he forced out, unable to keep his smile up and letting it shift back down to his usual frown. "Right. We'll have our first *business* meeting on Friday. I don't expect you to know everything right away, so don't worry," he would have to go along with this, and try again when his confidence wasn't so shattered anymore. But, no, no, he had to get away, get some space from

Entrapta to try and collect the shards of himself before he tried to face her again.

Turning around, Hordak walked away to leave her to her own research and to find something, anything to distract himself. “Octavia!” he called out, finding the older woman by some boxed drones. “If you’re done restocking the shelves, grab some window cleaner and towels and clean the glass on the doors and windows —I can see all the grubby little handprints all over it.” He was going to need more coffee after this.

Chapter End Notes

> Not gonna lie, it's weird writing Entrapta and Hordak and I don't know why. Also, wanna say thank you for all the kudos this fic's gotten in such a short time.

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

The one where The Super Pal Trio + DT chat between shifts.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The group was seated at the food court, trays and cups from the various different shops littering the table. Double Trouble's tail moved from side to side every few moments, a smile that promised nothing good planted on their lips as they drank from a large soda cup. Across from them was Entrapta, tearing apart an old Nokia flip phone, wires and bits all over her empty food tray. Beside her, Scorpia was animatedly talking about a recent trip, pinchers waving about, smiling so wide it was a wonder her face didn't fall off, and beside Double Trouble was Catra, leaning against the table with a lazy smile and resting her cheek on her hand as she listened to Scorpia.

"It was amazing!" Scorpia exclaimed, throwing her arms up into the air, eyes sparkling. "Then the bird just started tugging at my mom's hair, and the two of us couldn't help but laugh as she tried to get it to stop. The zookeeper had to come over and help because the hawk didn't want to leave."

Catra chuckled, taking a sip of her cola, tail swishing back and forth in a lazy manner as she listened. "Sounds about right for your bunch," she commented and gave a toothy grin. "I'm glad you and your moms had fun on the trip. It's nice that you still spend time with them."

"Of course I'd still spend time with them, they're family. Just because I'm all grown up and out of the house doesn't mean I have to forget about them," Scorpia seemed rather proud as she said that, pinchers on her hips and chest puffed out. Family was

important to her, just as important as her friendships were, it's just another thing about her that made Scorpia so amazing.

Today was one of those weird days for the group, where their schedules just barely aligned. Catra and Entrapta were on break at the moment, while Scorpia had just finished her shift and Double Trouble, well, as far as the group knew, they were here early for either a shift they picked up for someone at one of the stores, or here to watch and cause trouble. It was always a gamble for which it would be.

But, they had a brief period of time to actually meet up and talk before returning to their respective areas of work, it was something they enjoyed, just eating and chatting together without the stress of needy customers or overbearing bosses hanging around them like a noose. Especially with catching back up with Scorpia after she'd been gone a week on that family trip of hers to a zoo out of state.

Abruptly, Entrapta shoved her Nokia phone, or rather all the pieces of it, into a small baggie that in turn was put inside of her larger bag. "I should be returning to the Fright Zone about now," she declared after looking at the clock. "Break is almost over, and there's plenty of work to do."

"Ah, about that, how's everything been since your sudden promotion?" Double Trouble asked with a coy smile.

Entrapta didn't smile though, she had a thoughtful expression like she was trying to solve some sort of puzzle that was missing a few pieces. "It's been strange, if I'm being honest. There's a lot more work, and Hordak is trusting me with more managemental tasks, which is good. I'm getting more opportunities to learn a field I never considered before, and I have the chance to study social interactions during business meetings," she listed, leaning on her hair like it was a counter for her.

"But?" Catra arched an eyebrow. Despite how good everything sounded, the way Entrapta said it made it seem that there was

more to it.

“He’s been strange ever since he offered me the position,” she admitted. “I thought he would be happy that I agreed, but he seemed disappointed, and I can’t fathom why he'd be visibly bothered by my acceptance. My observations have also shown that he’s also been rather tense lately, and trying to limit his contact with me, particularly when it’s just the two of us. I’m worried that I may have overstepped some boundaries that I didn’t notice.”

Scorpia offered a comforting smile, reaching out to pat her hair, “I’m sure you did nothing wrong. He’s probably on edge because of Prime. You know how he gets when the big boss is involved.”

“Just give it some time and I’m sure he’ll be back to his usual stick-up-the-ass self in no time,” Catra added with a laugh.

“You’re right,” Entrapta nodded, slinging her bag over a shoulder and fishing out her recorder from one of the pockets. “Patience is key here, but if he’s upset over something Prime did, perhaps I can make him some tea to help him feel better, I hear it’s supposed to help calm people down.” She was already walking away, talking into her recorder and her voice growing distant as she made her way back to the Fright Zone’s tech store.

The group just watched her go with grins and heads shaking.

Double Trouble was the first to speak up after she left. “I feel sorry for Hordak, all his attempts and she never seems to notice.”

Shaking her heat, Catra finished off the last of her soda. “Entrapta’s smart, but she can be clueless at times. Knowing her, however, she probably never realizes he’s asking her out because she thinks they’re already a thing,” she offered and then shrugged, “Or maybe she really is that clueless when it comes to romance. Either way, my money is that they’ll become official within the year.”

“Oh, *Kitten*,” there was a glint is Double Troubles eyes as they spoke. “You should know better. I’ll happily take you up on that bet, knowing those two it’ll take them longer than a year if no one intervenes. Does twenty dollars sound fair?”

It was hardly a question needing an answer, the competitive spark had been lit, and Catra’s grin turned challenging, “You’re on.”

Scorpia just looked between the lizard and cat, blinking as she tried to figure out what was even going on. “Wait… Hordak has a crush on Entrapta?” she asked, eyes lighting up like it was the cutest thing she had ever heard. "Oh gosh, that's adorable, they'd make a really good couple!"

The tension was gone, replaced by sighs. Shaking her head, Catra patted Scorpia on the arm, “Oh, Scorpia, you take the trophy for most oblivious woman in the mall,” she sympathized. “Don’t worry about it too much, okay?”

“That reminds me, how have things been with you and that darling Lonnie?” Double Trouble asked, changing the topic of love from Entrapta onto Scorpia.

Instantly, the large woman’s face lit up like a Christmas tree, she waved her pinchers about in defense and shook her head. “There’s nothing going on, really,” she said and gave a sheepish laugh, “I just think that she’s really cool, and she always seems interested in listening to me and sparring with me. It’s not like we’re dating or anything, we’re just friends.” From her side of the table, Catra turned to Double Trouble mouthed *‘Oblivious’* to them.

Chuckling they stretched their arms high above their head, “Well, I will say that seeing as you *finally* got over your crush on Kitten here, I can say that you’ve finally developed good taste in women.”

“Hey!” Catra kicked them from under the table. “Excuse you, I am a *snack*!”

“Is that so? Well, I suppose some people like their treats bitter and salty.” Double Trouble mused, earning another kick from Catra.

Chapter End Notes

I have no idea what this chapter is, it went a completely different direction from what I had initially planned. But, either way, here you go.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

In which Kyle is doing his best.

“Venti no-foam caramel latte with whole milk and a shot of vanilla, for Alex?” Kyle called out and he brought the drink to the counter, peering at the array of customers loitering in the Coffee Horde. He watched as a tall, middle-aged woman approached the counter, not looking up from her phone, and felt a familiar rock drop in his gut as she made for the coffee.

He didn’t let go of it as she came up, “Venti caramel latte, no-foam with whole milk and vanilla?” he asked her carefully.

She barely looked up from her phone, “Oh, yeah, that’s mine,” she answered.

The rock in his gut didn’t go away, and so Kyle glanced at the name Lonnie had written on the cup. “Alex?”

“Yeah.”

Maybe his fears were for nothing, maybe it was just a byproduct of the stress and lack of sleep. So he swallowed back his apprehension and gave the woman the drink. She said that it was hers, and that she was Alex—and it wasn’t as if anyone else was coming up to claim it. Best to hand off the drink and be done with it.

Turning away from the counter, Kyle glanced over to where Lonnie was working the register, taking some new orders while Rogelio was making drinks like a pro. They were both doing much more than he was, Catra had put Kyle on expediting, to hand out the drinks when they were done. Took no real skill, and she said it was something even he could do without messing it up.

Well, it wasn't as if Rogelio could call out drinks. Lonnie was the best on the register, so really he was the only one left to do it.

Speaking of Catra, their shift manager was in the, probably putting the afternoon counts in the system or whatever it was managers did when the door was closed, so it just left Kyle, Lonnie and Rogelio to man the front at the moment. Not that it was bad, that's usually how it went.

He hadn't even gotten to return to Rogelio to grab whatever drinks he'd just finished before Alex stormed back to the counter, drink in hand and looking pissed. The anxiety returned.

"This isn't what I ordered," she snapped as soon as Kyle approached her, slamming her cup onto the counter. "Whatever this crap is, that's not what I paid for."

Kyle wrung his hands, glancing nervously around him—he hated confrontation like this, didn't know how to act when customers got like this. "I'm sorry, Alex, was the vanilla shot missing? Or, um, was it not a caramel latte?" he asked, trying to grasp for what was wrong with it when she wouldn't say.

"I ordered an iced cinnamon macchiato," Alex was close to yelling and Kyle wanted to shrink back. "Who the hell is Alex? My name's Karen, you know, the name on the cup!"

At this point, Rogelio had turned around to watch them, as had Lonnie. Kyle glanced away and saw that even Catra had come out of the office to watch, leaning against the doorframe, her face was a mask, but her ears and tail gave way to her feelings through how the tail lashed about and her ears pressed back. She wasn't going to step in, she wanted him to handle this, she wanted him to get better at handling these situations.

So many people were staring, he felt like he was going to die, it was too much, too overwhelming.

"I'm sorry, but, um, then why did you—" Kyle didn't get to finish before Karen blew up on him.

"Why did *I?* Are you trying to make this *my* fault?" Karen snapped, glaring at him like he was the dirt on her shoes. "Do you treat all your customers that way?"

Kyle flinched back, taking a step away from her and tried to find his voice, he wanted to disappear, to sink down and hide.

"He called out for a caramel latte for Alex, he asked you when you came over if yours was the caramel latte if you were Alex and you said yes," Lonnie had slid up to stand beside Kyle, arms crossed over her chest. "If it was clearly not your macchiato, why did you say it was your drink and take it?"

The woman, Karen, looked aghast at the accusation, looked ready to tear into them for talking back. Kyle took another step back as if to hide behind Lonnie, heard Rogelio let out a low growl as he started towards them. "I demand to see your manager!" Karen yelled, scowling.

"And I'd be happy to talk with you," Catra smiled as she walked towards them, seeing a moment to step in. "Kyle, Lonnie, could you two help Rogelio with the other drinks, we'll have to remake the latte."

"Come on, Kyle," Lonnie nodded, ushering him over to the machines while Catra talked with Karen.

The conversation wasn't the quietest with how Karen was growing more and more livid with each sentence. He tried to keep his attention off of it, helping Rogelio and Lonnie as best as he could, though he spilled a few drinks, burned his fingers on the coffee, got a few syrups mixed up. He did his best, that's all he'd been trying to do ever since he started working here.

Lonnie and Rogelio didn't seem to get upset when he got things wrong and they had to fix it. Maybe it was because they felt bad for him having to deal with customers like Karen, maybe it was just pity. He appreciated it, regardless of why they were being nice and tolerating him.

Eventually, the woman stormed off and Catra came over, leaning against the wall with her arms crossed. “Kyle, Rogelio, how about you two head out on break,” she said, jerking a thumb towards the door. “Lonnie and I can handle the counter for a while. You two get a breather, alright?”

Kyle blinked, “You sure?” he asked carefully as Rogelio wiped his hands clean on his apron. “I mean, if you’re sure, alright.” It wasn’t like he was against it and it was clear that he wasn’t given a choice because Rogelio was already grabbing his hand and tugging him away.

Lonnie chuckled as Kyle was led away, “Have a quick date you two,” she teased, to which Catra laughed along, grabbing a few cups to start making coffee. “Take a thirty minute rest.”

Kyle couldn’t say he was against it, he gave a smile as he entwined his fingers around Rogelio’s, nodding his head, “Alright, thank you,” he couldn’t help but chuckle a little as Rogelio impatiently tugged him along, eager to get away.

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

In which Shadow Weaver is here.

Chapter Notes

I don't really know what this chapter is. But I hope you like it.

"GLIMMER!"

The heads of virtually every customer within the bakery snapped towards the entrance as Adora ran in, face red, breathing heavily, and just *yelled* Glimmer's name. Bow was right behind her, not being too helpful as he looked around like a scared puppy searching for his friend, asking some customers they passed if they had seen the woman in question.

It took every ounce of self-control that Shadow Weaver possessed to stay where she was and look to the customers that this was fine and that everything was under control, though she would have very much liked to reach over and wrap her fingers around their throats and discipline them on why, regardless of if they worked that day or not, they should not barge into an establishment shouting like barbarians.

Unfortunately, Angella wasn't quite as…*lenient*… towards her way of maintaining order as Hordak had been. She would much rather try and tame these uncouth, wild teenagers and adults with empty words and little action when Shadow Weaver knew that if you wanted someone to do as you said, force was required.

It was frustrating some days. Understandably, she couldn't do anything to the customers, their repeated business was required, but back at the Coffee Horde, she had been allowed to pull employees who were acting out aside and *remind* them that they were to behave. But, Angella had made it very clear that Shadow Weaver was not to touch any of the employees when she allowed

her to work at the bakery, and Shadow Weaver loathed to admit it, but she would never have gotten the job after Hordak had the audacity of *firing* her if her former apprentice, Micah of all people, hadn't vouched for her.

Oh, Hordak was still a sore spot. Had it not been for that wretched girl, Catra, Shadow Weaver would have still been enjoying the luxury and power she had at the Coffee Horde. She had worked there faithfully for twelve years. Twelve. Years. And then he fires her! The nerve!

The two of them would get what's coming to them, Shadow Weaver would make sure of that. If she had to work in such a disgustingly colorful and sugary bakery to do so, she would, but she would make sure that Hordak understood his mistake when he got rid of her, and would make sure that Catra regretted ever standing against her. Their days were coming, it was just a matter of time, just a—

"Shadow Weaver!" Adora yelled, yanking Shadow Weaver out of her mental monologue when she slammed her hands onto the counter so hard that the little jars shook and threatened to fall.

Restraint, Shadow Weaver reminded herself, be calm, breathe. "Ah, Adora. What may I do for you today?" she asked sweetly. Even still, Adora was still her favorite, practically a daughter to Shadow Weaver, and she tried to show this motherly affection she had for the blonde by reaching out to her.

Adora jerked away from Shadow Weaver's hand, frowning hard and her brows furrowed.

"Shadow Weaver," that was Bow cutting in, taking a careful step between the two women, as if the counter itself wasn't enough of a wall for them. "Have you seen Glimmer? Or Angella?" he asked, his fingers fidgeting against each other nervously, the boy just radiated anxiety, it was almost as bad as the pure panic that Adora was exuding.

Of course they would be looking for those two. Shadow Weaver did her best not to sigh in annoyance. “No, I can’t say that I have. Haven’t you tried giving either of them a call?”

“Do you really think that we didn’t try that already?” Adora asked, crossing her arms over her chest.

Was it Catra who made her so… rebellious to Shadow Weaver, or had it been her friendship with Bow and Glimmer that made her so? Ah, Shadow Weaver missed the early days when Adora had first joined Coffee Horde, back when she was so obedient and ready to do anything to please Shadow Weaver and Hordak.

Still, Shadow Weaver just tilted her head to the side, watching them carefully. “Of course. But, if I may ask. What has happened that has the both of you so… frazzled?”

At her question, the two just looked at each other like they were surprised at the question, and it infuriated Shadow Weaver. It meant that there had been something and that she was out of the loop. She did not like being out of the loop.

“Shadow Weaver,” Bow spoke up again, this time carefully and cautiously as he took a step closer. “You really don’t know? Micah’s missing.”

“I would have thought *you* of all people would have known! He’s like your former student or something! Your *boss*?!” Adora threw her hands up into the air. “We’re trying to find Glimmer because we want to make sure she’s okay!”

Oh. It was just that. And here Shadow Weaver had thought it would have been something important. But no, it was just some trivial issue. “I see. Well, I do wish you the best of luck finding her.”

Bow quirked an eyebrow at her nonchalant response, watching as Shadow Weaver moved to start wiping down some muffin crumbs from the counter. “You… don’t care, do you?” the way he had

phrased it, it wasn't much of a question and was rather a statement, an accusation.

"I'm sure he'll be found before too long," Shadow Weaver responded as she continued to work on cleaning. "You're simply overreacting." She had no doubt in her mind that Micah was going to turn up sooner or later, the fool was just too stubborn to die that easily.

Adora looked as if Shadow Weaver had slapped her across the face, fury in her eyes and looking ready to jump over the counter just to get at the woman. She probably would have too, had Bow not thrown himself between them to keep her back.

"You're terrible," Adora growled out, her fingers curling and uncurling. "You're heartless."

"I don't think that's quite your place to decide," Shadow Weaver chuckled. Words were just words, there was nothing Adora could ever say that would bother her in the way the blonde wanted it to. Her skin was hardly as thin and fragile as theirs.

Adora only looked angrier and angrier, but Bow began pushing her back towards the entrance, trying to get them out before they made a scene. Or, rather, a bigger scene. The customers were still watching them like this was some stage born drama unfolding before their eyes. Really, had they nothing better to do than watch and stare?

"Come on, Adora," Bow whispered, having gotten her towards the threshold. "Let's try someplace else. She might be with someone else, and if she's not here, we can try her place."

Still glaring at Shadow Weaver, Adora huffed and gave in. "Fine, alright," she muttered, letting him guide her away.

Children. How pitiful. Shadow Weaver shook her head and resumed her duties. Irresponsible, reckless, it was such a shame to see them act like this. Shadow Weaver held the towel between her long, boney fingers and glanced back towards the kitchen,

staring down at the employees who had stopped working, have ceased working since Adora and Bow had arrived.

She gave a dark chuckle. “And who said that you could stop and dawdle?” she asked darkly. Before her eyes, three hurried to get back to baking and cleaning. Ah, even without the same authority Hordak had given her, she could still hold some power over her new acquaintances.

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

> In which the sports store Desert Rose and the specialty store Salineas are right across from one another.

"Thank you for coming, and may I say that you will have the most adventurous time on the river with your new kayak! One of our staffs will help you to load it into your vehicle, and I do very much hope to see you two here again for anything else you might need."

The customers, a pair of women, smiled, though it seemed rather strained and very uncomfortable at how loud and energetic Sea Hawk was as he rang them up at checkout. The two were fairly quick to leave Salineas as well once they had their change.

Mermista groaned as she came over, dressed in the uniform smock of her dads store. "Can you, like, *not* scare the customers off?"

"Why I'd never!" Sea Hawk responded with an offended gasp, though there was no bite behind it at all. "They love me, Mermista, and I have to give it my all for each and everyone of them so that they come back here and not to any other store!"

And by any other store, he was really just referring to the sporting goods that was right across from theirs. Sea Hawk even moved to look out through their glass front to glare at the store. His glare shrunk back when Huntara, who had been adjusting the hiking gear one of the mannequins, noticed him staring and looked to him and Mermista.

Huntara had only started up her store, the Desert Rose, four years ago, having been working various different jobs to get both a license and enough money to start off. In all honesty, both Mermista and Sea Hawk were both impressed by what she had

done. She was only twenty-eight and she owned her own rather well-off store. If anything, the Desert Rose was the go-to sports store in the mall.

Crossing her arms, Mermista leaned against the checkout counter. "It's not that big of a deal if people go there or not," she drawled out. "They have variety and crap for all sorts of things. We're a specialty store. Of course people are going to go to Desert Rose when they need stuff for like… basketball or something. It's not like we're rival stores or anything."

"Nonsense!" Sea Hawk argued, pushing himself from the cash register. There were enough employees milling about that he felt he had no need to tether himself to the register, not when there was more he could do to draw in more customers. "People are always going to the Desert Rose for everything, and she's taking away our customers, I'd say she is very much our rival. We must do something to bring more people to us!"

"Whatever your planning. No."

"What? But why?"

Mermista crossed her arms over her chest, scowled and groaned. "Last time you tried something extravagant to bring people in, you nearly set the mall on fire with your flaming kayak. You're lucky my dad didn't fire you for it."

The flaming kayak had been an…interesting event last summer. At first Sea Hawk had it under control and the fire contained, but as usual, he lost control of the situation and the kayak became a problem. The fire department had been called in, but by the time they'd arrived, Huntara had already put the fire out. If anything, that just got more people going to her store after her hour of heroics.

Mermista's father had been beyond angry. Even with Sea Hawks track record of being Employee of the Month most of the time, it hadn't done anything to ease the rage. He had almost been fired.

But, Mermista may had talked to her dad in private and convinced him to let Sea Hawk stay.

Not that anyone knew that she had a part to play, oh no, Mermista wasn't letting *anyone* know she put in the work and effort to help Sea Hawk keep his job. It'd ruin her whole aloof persona.

Though, just because Sea Hawk hadn't been fired didn't mean he wasn't on thin ice. Mermista doubted that if he set another thing on fire she would be able to keep her dad from firing him.

"Let's just let it be. Huntara's store isn't going to affect ours at… what the *Hell*?!" Mermista bristled as she stared at the Desert Rose, at the group of customers leaving.

The five people who had just left, probably a group by how close-knit they looked, were carrying out several life jackets and a boxed towable tube for boating. She couldn't make out what kind it was, but it almost looked like they had an Airhead Blast. They looked so happy, chatting and laughing with their new purchases.

Purchases they just got from Huntara.

"They did not," Mermista clenched her fists. "They went to the *Desert Rose* for that, and not here? The store *specifically* for water activities? What the Hell?"

"How dare they!" Sea Hawk gasped, offended not for himself but for Mermista.

Huntara noticed them watching and she just smiled and waved, acting as if she hadn't just stolen their customers from them, acting as if she wasn't moving in on their product territory.

"Sea Hawk," Mermista didn't even look at him as she spoke, "Do what you can to get people coming. We're not losing to Huntara. Just… don't set anything on fire this time, okay?"

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

The one where Catra and Frosta interact.

Catra had been minding her own business. Really, she had. She had just been sitting at a table in the food court, minding her own damn business.

Yeah, maybe she had been alone at the time. It was her day off and her friends were busy.

She had just been sitting around in the food court waiting for some of them to finish up their shifts so they could hang out. Nothing more to it. All that mattered was that Catra had been keeping quiet and not causing any trouble for once.

In fact, Catra had nothing to do with the trouble that started. She had been minding her business eating one of those big soft pretzels.

But the fact of the matter was, regardless of Catra, trouble started.

She ignored it at first, the mocking jeers and taunts, the snarky answers back. She just kept eating her pretzel and looking at her watch. Maybe she got there too early because there was still over an hour until the two would be done with their respective jobs, and that was if they weren't made to stay later because of something happening.

By the looks of it, most everyone else was also ignoring the apparent bullying going on in the food court. A few people would glance in the direction of the voices and quickly look away. Not wanting to get involved.

Catra couldn't blame them.

Eventually, though, curiosity got the better of her. Taking a bite out of her pretzel, Catra turned around in her seat to look and see just what was going on.

Surrounding one of the tables was a group around her age, a couple looked a little younger, one looked a bit older. Leather jackets and snakes on the back, Catra recognized Lashor's gang easily. What really took her by surprise was that they were circling and taunting Frosta of all people.

Now, Catra couldn't say the twelve-year-old was a friend of hers. No, Frosta was more of Scorpia and Adora's friend. Sure, Catra was friendly enough with the kid, as friendly as one ought to be to someone in your friend circle who's not *your* friend in particular.

Hell, the most they've done that went beyond simple hellos was when Frosta punched Catra in the face last week. Not that Catra could blame her. She was more impressed than anything, the kid had a good right hook.

Frosta's parents owned a winter gear store on the second floor of the shopping center, and the kid spent a lot of her time just wandering the mall and hanging out with people older than her, so seeing her wasn't unusual by any means.

No, what was odd was that Lashor's gang was picking on a twelve-year-old.

Finishing off her pretzel, Catra stood up and slowly made her way to their table, her tail swishing back and forth and her ears twitching a little.

She wasn't doing this for Frosta, she wasn't doing this to be a hero, of course not. That just wasn't her style. She just didn't like Tung Lashor and if she fucked up some of his goonies, that'd piss him off, and boy she got a kick out of pissing people off. Had nothing to do with her not liking grown ass adults picking on a kid.

“What, gonna cry?” hissed the bigger of the five, a bulky reptilian who spoke with a hiss. He leaned on the table and snatched fries that Frosta had probably been eating, downing them all in a single bite.

Another, a slim woman with goat horns cackled as she leaned against a shorter individual. “Cry for mommy and daddy?”

Frosta, for her part, was red in the face with embarrassment and rage, her hands shaking as she glared at them. “Go away before I make you.” It probably would have been more intimidating if Frosta wasn’t so small and so young. Instead of scaring the group off, the thugs just started laughing at her.

“Oh man, is this kid for real?” one of them wheezed, resting his elbow on her head. “Go away before I make you! Ah, that is hilarious.”

Catra smirked as she sauntered up, leaning against the table and looking at the gang, “What’s so funny?” she asked innocently, arms crossed over her chest and tail curling behind her. The laughter stopped when she spoke.

Now that Catra was at the table and getting a proper look at the group, she recognized two of them, the goat-woman and her small four-armed companion. Two people Catra had already beaten up and earned respect from. For those two, they clammed up as soon as Catra had spoken, backing away a little. The others, though? Not quite as easy to chase off.

“Aw? A kitty coming to the rescue?” the reptilian mocked, looking down on Catra. “You think you’re tough, how adorable.”

Catra smiled, raised a hand and let her claws extend. “I can show you just how tough I am if you want.”

She knew his kind. He was all talk, the type who relied on his intimidating appearance and bravado to scare people into submission. Catra knew how to deal with that, it was to show that you weren’t scared and that you were confident in your ability to

take him down. She smirked, eyes locked on his as she let her claws slowly dig into the table, leaving deep scratches in the surface.

Almost a minute passed before the thug broke her gaze, taking an uncertain step back as he glared and glowered. "She's not even that much fun, anyway," he muttered as if to protect his own pride, and began stalking away with his entourage following.

"While you go, tell Lashor hello for me," Catra called after with a laugh, they flipped her off which only made her mood that much better.

"I didn't need your help."

Ah, there it was.

Catra was still smirking as she turned to look at Frosta, meeting her glare with amusement. Frosta, so prideful, so reluctant to rely on help. She reminded Catra of herself in a way. Catra faintly remembered Adora talking about how Frosta treated her when they first met, trying to act like she was mature and capable when really she was just a kid.

"I'm sure you could have," Catra said, sinking into a chair.

Bristling, Frosta moved to stand. "I could have dealt with them on my own! I didn't need you to interfere, I didn't ask for you to help me!"

"Hey, who said I was helping you?" Catra asked in response, watching Frosta and chuckling a bit when Frosta looked absolutely confused. "If anything, I was just saving those idiots. If I hadn't stepped in, they would have been leaving in an ambulance once you got through with them."

Ah. There it was.

Frosta smiled. Well, it was less of a smile and more of a smug grin. "Well, of course. I was just waiting for the right moment to

punch them in their stupid faces," and as if to accentuate the point, she balled her hands into fists and raised them up to the air.

She couldn't help it, not really, but Catra grinned and laughed. "Their faces are pretty dumb looking."

Leaning back and glancing to the ceiling, Catra hummed, her smiling falling as she started to think. She *could* just leave right now. She stepped in, Lashor's gang backed off, Frosta could take care of herself from here on out. But… well… Catra kind of didn't want to? Sure, Frosta wasn't *her* friend, but…

"I've still got some time to kill before Lonnie and Scorpia are done with work, want to hang out?" Catra asked, not really looking to Frosta. "I'm sure Scorpia would love to see you once she meets up with us, too. Better than just loitering about on your own, at least."

"Depends," Frosta said, bringing back up that ice queen façade, but Catra could see the cracks in it. "Can we play laser tag?"

Catra grinned, and it felt nice seeing Frosta smiling too.

Needless to say, the two of them were an unstoppable team once they geared up.

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

The one where Bright Moon Bakery is loud and chaotic.

Adora hadn't been sure *what* she had expected when she walked into the bakery that day at the mall. She had the day off and had just wanted to come and pick her friends up, and she had assumed everything would be normal. Glimmer would be at the counter, Bow would be helping to bring pastries out or cleaning the tables, Shadow Weaver would be looming in the corner glaring at everyone.

What Adora hadn't expected was for the bakery to be empty and for Angella to be yelling angrily while on the phone.

"Do you have *any idea* how worried we were?" she demanded, her wings growing ruffled with her clear frustration as she paced the back kitchen, coming in and out of view from the open door. "Do you?"

Ooooh boy. What had Adora just walked in on?

Carefully, she walked to the counter where Glimmer was slouched over on, face down on the cool marble surface, groaning quietly in a tone that just screamed 'Kill Me'.

"Heeeey Glimmer," Adora said, leaning against the other side of the counter, looking down at her friend. No sign of Bow, and Shadow Weaver was putting up new signs on the window. Other than her, it was just Glimmer and her very angry mom. "What's going on?" *Why is your mom angry? I've never seen her this angry.*

Glimmer raised her head just enough so that Adora could see her eyes and the heavy bags under them. "We found my dad."

"Oh! That's good, right?" That should be good. It was good. He'd been missing for a little over two weeks now, and they found him. "Why don't you seem happy?"

Groaning, Glimmer propped herself up on her elbows. "I'm happy that he's home and he's safe, don't get me wrong," she said carefully, looking over her shoulder to her still yelling and still pacing mother. "As you can see with my mom, we're just…*really* annoyed with him right now."

"Eh?"

Glimmer looked back to Adora, frowning, looking like she was carrying ten years' worth of exhaustion and stress on her face. "My dad was at Beast Island this whole time."

To that, Adora reeled back as if she had been smack in the face. "Beast Island? He went to *Beast Island*?" she asked, unable to believe Gimmer.

Beast Island was… well, obviously it was an island, that went without saying. It was a small island off the coast of the city. Thick forest, lots of wild life. People tended to stay away from it because it had a very large population of bears and generally wasn't exactly *safe*. Adora could still remember all the stories adults told when she was little about how bad kids got sent to Beast Island when they misbehaved.

"Yes. Beast Island," Glimmer confirmed, forcing the words out through gritted teeth. "Apparently he was on a meditative, soul-searching camping trip this whole time. The says he thought he told us about it, but clearly, he did not. Mom's probably going to make him sleep on the couch for a few days."

Adora rubbed her neck awkwardly. "Well, I'm glad that he's home and safe, but… wow…"

"I did say that he would be found before too long, did I not?" Shadow Weaver cut in, seemingly gliding across the floor as she

approached the two. Her words had been directed at Adora, a hint of smugness to them.

Glimmer groaned, collapsing against the counter once again. "My family is dumb," she decided. "My dad is unbelievable."

"I'm sure it's not that bad. Give it a day or two and things will calm down," Adora tried, placing a comforting hand on Glimmers shoulder.

"You could have at least taken a phone! We had the police scouring every inch of the city for you! We thought you'd gotten kidnapped!" Angella yelled, her voice rising in pitch. There was the faint sound of something metal being knocked over, likely a pot by her wings.

Adora flinched at the commotion and looked back down at Glimmer "How about we head out, get out of here before Angella starts throwing things, take your mind off of all of this? We can go grab Catra and hang out—she was telling me last night about this new store that opened up, the three of us can go and check it out."

At the mention of Catra, Adora could just *hear* Shadow Weaver rolling her eyes.

"Heh, that's not a bad idea," Glimmer agreed, raising her head up again to crack a small grin. "And if the store turns out to be a bust, I'm sure I can get some enjoyment out of riling her up."

"That's the spirit!" Adora smiled, watching as Glimmer finally stood up straight and started walking. She liked seeing Glimmer like this —smiling and moving—more than when she was throwing herself across surfaces because she was stressed and angry.

Shadow Weaver moved to the side in that weird gliding, is she even touching the ground, kind of way. "I still do not see why either of you would ever wish to spend time with *Catra* of all people," she said, a bite to her words as she mentioned the magicat.

“Uh,” Adora raised a brow, “Because she’s our friend?”

Even to this day, Adora could not understand *why* Shadow Weaver hated Catra so much. At least Catra had a reason to hate Shadow Weaver after how she was treated, but Shadow Weaver seemed to have had it out for Catra since they first started working at the Coffee Horde. Maybe the woman just didn’t like cat-people. Which wasn’t exactly good, either.

Either way, it had become so common for Shadow Weaver to have some kind of remark or snark when Catra was the topic that neither Adora nor Glimmer really paid it any mind anymore.

“She’s really not that bad if you get to know her,” Glimmer added with a slight shrug of her shoulders, “and that’s coming from someone who hated her for the longest time. She’s fun and cool.” And an absolute doofus. But, who in their friend group wasn’t?

Shadow Weaver scoffed. “Misguided ideas. But I don’t think anyone who’s full name includes ‘Applesauce Meowmeow’ can be considered *cool*.”

None of the three women even had a chance to say anything before a door was thrown open and Bow ran in, jumping over a table to get to them, his eyes wide, full of hearts and sparkles as he stood in front of Shadow Weaver. “Her full name is *what*?”

“What the fuck?” Adora whispered, having almost been knocked aside by him. “Where did you come from?” Had they just summoned him by bringing up Catra's name?

She was ignored.

And Shadow Weaver seemed to think this might have been a good opportunity to perhaps ruin Catra’s image or reputation because she didn’t hesitate. She chuckled in that ‘I’m going to enjoy this’ tone, brought her arms behind her back, and looked down at Bow. “Her name is Catra Applesauce Meowmeow.”

As if the heart eyes couldn't get any more intense, Bow brought his hands to his face and gave a tiny squeal. "That is so *cute*! Is it true, is it really true, Adora?"

Adora, for her part, brought one hand to her forehead, then dragged it down to pinch the bridge of her nose. She knew where this was going, and it wasn't going to end pretty. "Catra *will* kill you if you ever say it out loud."

That was enough confirmation because Bow gasped, "Her last name is so cute, how can that even be?" Even Glimmer was laughing, hand to her mouth and tears in the corner of her eyes. "She always seemed so tough and scary, but her last name is *Meowmeow* and it's too adorable, it's just too adorable!"

"You do not get to bring Castaspella into this!"

"And her middle name! It's Applesauce? That's just—oooh!"

"I can't believe all this time she was teasing us for our names, giving me crap for being Bright, and then hers is *Applesauce Meowmeow*. That's just—ahaha!"

"Don't you hang up, we are not done talking about this!"

"How mad do you think she'd be if I asked her about it? I want to tell her how cute her name is!"

"Adora, how did you know this and not tell us?"

"Micah!"

Adora took a deep breath, tuning out all the words around her. People were stopping outside the store to stare and see what the commotion was. Some kids even pointed and started talking to their parents, diverting more attention. Catra, she was sorry, but looks like the entire mall was going to learn her secret before long.

All the while, Shadow Weaver just leaned back in a chair and somehow looked incredibly smug even with the mask hiding her face.

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

The one where Perfuma has a heart to heart with Scorpia.

Chapter Notes

Whispers Yes, I'm still alive and this fic is still active. I've never written Perfumas POV before, so this was an adventure.

Perfuma had been having a good day. Actually, she had been having a good week.

The drum circle she had hosted over the weekend gained three new members—Oh, how wonderful it had been to show them the ropes! Even her meditation session with Catra went better than it usually did, and she was oh so proud of her friend for how far she had come! When they had first started these weekly sessions all those years ago, Catra had been so angry, filled with so much negative energy that she didn't know how to let go. But now she was happier, and Perfuma was proud of her.

She even had a slight boom in business lately. Not many people came to her flower store (Perhaps a mall had not been the perfect location, but that had not been her decision to make), so most days went by slow with her tending to all the flowers. But lately more and more people were putting in orders, it made her heart soar to see such an increase interest in plants.

She couldn't have been happier, and it had Perfuma practically prancing about the flower shop, a song on her lips as she watered the flowers all around.

But, for every good, something bad was bound to happen, and she found that when the door opened with the distinct chime of the bell. Turning around, Perfuma beamed as she saw Scorpia come shuffling in. "Ah! Good morning, Scorpia!" Perfuma greeted.

Scorpia smiled, though it was strained in comparison to her usual ones, “Ah, hey, Perfuma,” she greeted as she pulled a gardening apron on, her tone rather, well, not Scorpia.

She seemed to be oozing negative energy in comparison to the happy, positive woman Perfuma was used to, and it just wasn’t right, wasn’t normal.

Putting the watering can down, Perfuma frowned and made her way over to her friend. “Hey, Scorpia,” she began, placing her hand on a large bicep, “Is everything okay? You look rather down.” Well, that was a bit of an understatement.

Scorpia looked like someone had stolen something she loved dearly and ignored the value placed on it as they trashed it. She looked like she was trying her hardest to hide how devastated she felt by putting on a brave face and failing. It was heartbreaking to see Scorpia look so sullen. The last time Perfuma had seen her like that was when she and Catra had their big falling out a few years ago, where she got rejected by her best friend after having a crush for so long.

Wait…

“It’s nothing,” Scorpia said, smiling that strained smile once more, shrugging Perfuma’s hand off. “Really, nothing for you to bother yourself with. Hey, let’s get to work, these flowers must be pretty thirsty, right?”

Scorpia awkwardly tried to scoot past Perfuma, which she could have easily done given their size differences, but Scorpia wasn’t the type to just shove someone else aside so she could get by. And, with Perfuma refusing to budge an inch, Scorpia was left just trapped in the back corner of the store with all the spare aprons.

She laughed nervously, her scorpion tail raising and lowering anxiously behind her as she pressed the tips of her pincers together. “I, ah, can’t really get to work when you’re standing there, Perfuma,” she said carefully. “I mean, I don’t really want to

accidentally knock you over, so if you could, um, just move to the side a little?"

"Not until you tell me what's wrong," Perfuma said firmly, crossing her arms over her chest. She could be stern and unmoving when needed, and this felt like a moment that needed that firmness.

Scorpia couldn't even look her in the eyes. "It's nothing, really. Come on, Perfuma. We don't want to slack off, do we?"

"It's Lonnie, wasn't it?"

To that, Scorpia stiffened, her breath hitched loudly, and Perfuma knew she hit the mark. Slowly, the woman lowered her head, her shoulders drooping in defeat. "I…ah…" she swallowed, hard, finding her words. "How'd you know?"

The only thing that could describe what Perfuma felt was sympathy. Sympathy for her friend. "Do you want to talk about it?" she said instead.

There was a long pause, as if Scorpia trying to decide if she did want to talk or not. Slowly, she raised her head up once more to look at Perfuma. "I thought we were really hitting it off, you know? We liked hanging out, we shared a few interests. She's fun. A good person, a good friend—and I hoped we could be more than that. I thought she did, too." She let her head drop down once more. "I asked her this morning, but I guess I had my hopes out for nothing."

Scorpia's crush on Lonnie hadn't been a secret, virtually everyone in their circle of friends had known, and Perfuma would be lying to herself if she said she never felt a twinge of jealousy whenever Scorpia gushed about Lonnie when they hung out. But she, like everyone else, had figured that Lonnie had felt the same. It was rather surprising to hear that Lonnie had rejected her.

A little relieving, too, not that Perfuma was going to pay that feeling any mind. No, no, she was going to shove it back to sort out at a later date, this wasn't the time for her own feelings to

rear their heads up, no, she had to focus on helping her dear friend feel better.

"Oh, Scorpia, I'm so sorry," Perfuma said, and it was true. Regardless of how she might feel, what was more important to her was that Scorpia was happy, even if it wasn't with her. Seeing Scorpia heartbroken hurt her just as much. "I'm sorry about what happened with her, I truly am."

Scorpia gave her a tired smile. "I hate to say it, but I'm starting to think that it's me. That—that there's something about me that pushes everyone I like away? It was a stroke of luck Catra and I were able to be friends again after I almost ruined our friendship with my crush, and now I probably just lost Lonnie as a friend because of it, too. Do you think there's something about me that makes me, just, not good for a relationship?"

What? "No! No, no, no!" Perfuma yelled a tad too loud if how Scorpia flinched was anything to go by. She took a breath to bring her voice back down, to try and calm down, but it was harder to find that sense of tranquility here. She managed to, however, and gave her friend a gentle smile. "Scorpia, you are *wonderful*. You're beautiful, loyal, the kindest person I have ever met. There is nothing about you that would make people shy away from being with you."

She was speaking from the heart, trying to convey just how wonderful a person Scorpia was, how amazing. Scorpia was almost too good for the world, and she wanted her to know.

Taking in a breath, Scorpia released it in a low whistle, "I, ah, do you really mean all that?"

"Of course," Perfuma nodded, taking Scorpia's pincers in her hands and looking her in the eyes. "Never, *ever* think that there's something wrong with you. You are perfect just the way you are, and you will find someone who loves and cherishes you just as much as you do them. Perhaps that person wasn't Catra, and perhaps not Lonnie, but you still have a long future ahead of you

to find her, and you'll have your friends at your side the entire time to support you."

"Thank you," It was quiet at first, and then louder. "Thank you. I'll, I'll do my best to remember that. I think I'm just going to need some time for now, to get over what happened with Lonnie, to get my mind off of all of this for now."

Smiling, Perfuma let go of her and backed away, providing her room to get to the rest of the store. "Well, tending to flowers can be very relaxing."

Scorpia laughed, passing Perfuma as she made her way further into the store. Perfuma could hear the clank of metal as she grabbed one of the watering cans, a rack shuddering as she almost knocked over one of the hanging pot rack on her journey to fill the can with water. With a smile still on her face, Perfuma crossed her arms over her middle, feeling butterflies in her chest.

Regardless of how she felt, even if Scorpia's 'her' wasn't her in the end, Perfuma would be content so long as Scorpia found her special someone, the person who made her happy no matter what. That would be enough for her.

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

Netossa and Spinnerella's commentary on those around them.

Chapter Notes

Okay I just really wanted to write some Spintossa, and I also wanted to write some text messaging. So I did them both in one.

(Tue, Jul 20, 12:03 PM)

Netossa

At this point

I'm starting to think we'll have to step in.

Spinnerella

Hm?

Netossa

Our baby gays.

@ BM RN

Watched Glimmer spend 5 mins

5 WHOLE minutes

Flirting with Adora.

I don't think Adora even realized it was flirting.

Spinnerella

Oh dear…

My heart really does break for her

She’s trying so hard.

Netossa

Adora can be pretty oblivious.

Hell, both of them are rather oblivious.

Scratch that! All of them are oblivious!

Even the straight ones!

Spinnerella

Ah, speaking of…

Netossa

?

Spinnerella

I went to the Fright Zone on my way to work

Got you a new charger

Netossa

Thank you love

Spinnerella

You’re quite welcome, darling.

But, I saw Hordak while I was there.

I don’t think he saw me, or else he likely would have left.

It looked like he was rehearsing confessions.

I can only assume he’s still struggling to get his feelings across to Entrapta.

Netossa

He’s making it so much harder than it actually is.

Just go and tell her!

It's not hard!

Spinnerella

It’s easy to say now.

But I do recall it taking you months to take that first step.

Ah, you were such a nervous, flustered mess

It was quite adorable.

Netossa

Ugh

You raise a fair point.

I guess it isn't THAT easy to confess...

(Tue, Jul 20, 1:17 PM)

Spinnerella

Image Sent

If you’re wondering why the sprinklers and fire alarms went off.

Netossa

I’ll give Sea Hawk credit

That is impressive.

Spinnerella

I can’t tell how much of the fire was intentional

And how much was a result of the original flame spreading.

Netossa

It’s a coin toss.

But, boy, does Mermista look mad.

Spinnerella

She does look upset.

Hopefully this doesn’t prove to be the last straw for her.

Netossa

Last straw?

With how much she loves him, they’ll be fine.

Spinnerella

You’re probably right.

They do make for quite an adorable couple.

Ah, Huntara’s helping to put out the fire.

Again.

Netossa

Huntara is basically the firefighter for this place

Considering she’s usually close by when Sea Hawk sets something on fire.

Spinnerella

They should give her a medal.

Netossa

They really should.

Spinnerella

There's a lot more debris than I expected from a burning canoe and inflatable dolphins.

I'm going to see if they would like help cleaning up.

(Tue, Jul 20, 3:46 PM)

Netossa

Image Sent

A smiling, white-haired Hordak.

I don't know whether to be terrified or amazed.

Spinnerella

I think that's his brother.

Don't know his name, but I have seen him around.

He's so different from him

If the two didn't share the same face I would never have guessed.

Netossa

It's creepy. They even sound identical.

I'm gonna go say hi to him.

(Tue, Jul 20, 5:30 PM)

Netossa

Image Sent

And another girl has fallen for the cat.

Spinnerella

Well, Catra does have that charm to her.

The girl looks familiar, though.

Netossa

I think her name is Flutterina?

Spinnerella

That sounds about right.

What did Catra do to win her over?

Netossa

Apparently she punched Rattlor in the face.

Spinnerella

That sounds like Catra.

I do hope she'll be okay, she's been getting into fights with his group quite frequently.

Netossa

She's tough.

I wouldn't worry too much about her.

The two seem to be hitting it off.

Glimmer & Adora might have some competition

Spinnerella

Oh dear!

Now that's a thought.

Netossa

Though, knowing the current track record

I will be surprised if Catra ever figures out this girl has a crush on her.

It's been years and she still hasn't caught on to Glimmer and Adora's.

Spinnerella

Lol.

She may surprise us.

Netossa

Anyway, I'm going head home

Do you need me to stop by the grocery store for anything?

Spinnerella

We're low on milk, and I think it wouldn't hurt to pick up bread and eggs.

Netossa

Got it.

See you tonight <3

Spinnerella

Stay out of trouble.

Love you.

Netossa

Love you more.

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

In which Hordak has a very unpleasant brunch meeting.

It was eleven in the morning, exactly on the dot, when Hordak walked through the door of the (new, expensive, and *very* upscale) restaurant that had been picked out for brunch, raging at himself beneath a cracking mask of stoicism. The agreed upon time was eleven. He should have arrived earlier, he shouldn't have arrived just at the time. There was no excuse, absolutely none, for his tardiness!

At a table by the window was Prime, looking to have been there for at least a little while. With one hand he was toying with the menu, and with the other he ran the metallic claw covering his finger along the rim of a water glass.

When he noticed Hordak approaching, he smiled.

Seeing his smile—it made Hordak feel small. Scared. Like the frightened child who was always hidden in his brothers shadows, groomed and molded to be a perfect replica, obeying every demand and command that came from the older brother's lips.

"Little brother," Prime greeted, louder than necessary, loud enough to draw attention from anyone sitting close, to draw their attention onto Hordak—so they could judge him in silence for his lateness. He placed the menu onto the table, gestured to one of the two empty seats. "I was beginning to worry that you wouldn't be able to come."

Hordak cursed himself. He should have arrived sooner. He shouldn't have made his brother wait. He should have—

He made his way to the offered seat, setting in and sitting ramrod straight. "I'm sorry, Prime," Hordak apologized with a shamed dip of his head.

He'd been on a call with Entrapta, so enthralled with listening to her rambles on the newest innovations she was trying on Emily, enthralled by her excitement and technological genius, enthralled by the sound of her voice and her genuine joy—he had let time pass and made the inexcusable mistake of making his elder brother *wait*.

He didn't blame Entrapta for this, no, this was Hordak's fault and his alone.

"Ah, but you're here now, that's what matters," Prime said with a simple wave of his hand, as if this insult had never happened. "Please, take a look at the menu. I must say, it has been so long since we've had a proper sit down to eat with one another."

They ate together infrequently, and when they did, it was almost always at Prime's penthouse, dining on extravagantly lavish dishes from across the world and drinking expensive wine as Prime talked about his latest plans to expand his corporate empire or the newest businesses he had brought into his light. Prime only ever ate at a restaurant if it were with his business partners, when he felt the need to spoil them to gain loyalty, information, obedience, and whatever else it was he desired from them.

It was as much part of manipulation to the weak-minded as it was a show of his affluence and finances by simply spending hundreds on a single meal.

"Of course," Hordak said, taking the menu with stiff movements and skimming over the contents. He couldn't help but feel rather underwhelmed by the options in comparison to what Prime would have his personal chefs cook at his own home. The meals offered felt mundane. Or, perhaps it was simply a sign of just how universally loved bacon and eggs were regardless of social class. Keeping those thoughts to himself, he dared a glance at Prime, who had begun gazing disinterestedly at passing people through the window. "What do you recommend?"

That got his attention, and Prime smiled once more. “Ah? Personally I am thinking of ordering some oyster stew, I *am* quite fond of seafood. Perhaps a light salad to go with it. Would you care to try?”

“If it’s all right.”

“Of course it would be,” with that, Prime gestured for a passing waiter, giving him their orders and menus and sending the young man on his way. Personally, Hordak did not like oysters, he did not like seafood in general, it caused his stomach discomfort when he ate. But, as they were Prime’s favorite, Hordak would always force himself to tolerate it in his brother’s presence. Undoubtedly, Prime was well aware of what seafood did to him, but he was always silent on the matter.

As they were left waiting for their food, Prime turned to Hordak and smiled once more. “Now, I think we should discuss your progress at that dingy mall you’ve been working on,” he said, crossing one leg over the other and brining his chin to rest on his knuckles. “How *are* your two stores doing, anyway? They haven’t proven to be too much for you, have they?”

Hordak stiffened even more, his mind gathering up the latest profits, records, and reviews. “Too much? They are almost too little,” he said. It was a lie, of course, managing one business was tricky, running two at once wasn’t entirely easy, but he couldn’t let Prime know, It’d be considered weakness. How dare Hordak struggle with *two* stores when Prime was thriving with *countless* under his thumb! It would be pathetic of him to fail at his given task!

“The Fright Zone has the highest profit rate out of all the electronic stores in Etheria,” he continued, almost robotically. “Our sales have been on a gradual, but consistent, rise for the past six months. While reviews are primarily positive, there are the occasional negative ones.”

“Hmm,” Prime didn’t look away, his smile had faded into a thoughtful frown. Hordak swallowed, scared, unable to show it. “And that coffee shop?”

His mind shifted from the Fight Zone to the coffee shop. “Coffee Horde is the second most popular coffee shop in Etheria. As with the Fright Zone, sales have been a steady climb upward. Our only real business rival is Bright Moon. While we provide better and more varied coffees, their pastries do outsell ours. I have been willing to overlook it seeing Coffee Horde is a coffee shop, not a bakery.”

“And who allowed you to?” Prime demanded. His voice hadn’t raised, it wasn’t angry, and yet there was a menacing bite to it. Hordak flinched back. “Coffee Horde sells pastries, as well as coffee, and many customers may come in for something such as a muffin or scone to go with their drink. Yet, you are fine with customers going to this ‘Bright Moon’ instead of the Horde? To give this other store our customers and profits? You find that *acceptable*?”

Fumbling for his words, Hordak could only dip his head down, look at his lap so he was no longer looking at Prime. “No, of course not.” He was glad that his brother could not see his hands balled up into fists on his lap. “I will… I will see to it that our recipes are improved, work on advertising our food more. Perhaps a limited time special or two to bring in more customers specifically for the pastries. Would that suffice?”

Finally, he looked back up at Prime, his brother looked thoughtful, one finger to his lips, before finally nodding. “If you succeed? Then, yes,” he conceded, but his eyes narrowed as he looked to Hordak once more. “When I next check in, I hope you have better news to tell me. Else, I may have to doubt your abilities and relocate you somewhere more…fitting for your ineptitude.”

Hordak looked down again. “Of course, Prime.”

The server had returned, two oyster stews and two small salads for them. Prime said something, a compliment to the young man, a simple urging for Hordak to eat before his food cooled and went to waste.

Yet, suddenly Hordak didn’t feel all that hungry.

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